

UPSC INDIAN POLITY

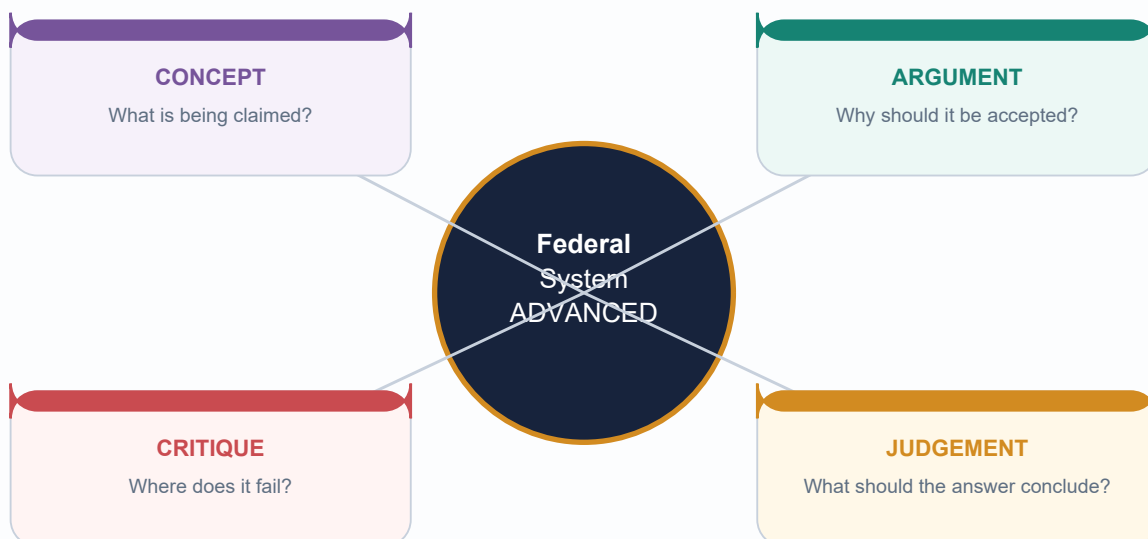
Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE Deep-Learning Visual Notes

Indian Polity · GS Paper II · Prelims + Mains

Layer 1: Basic foundation · Layer 2: Advanced constitutional and exam depth

Sources: Federal-System.md + 12_Federal-System.md

Learning cards: 18



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Foundation • Core Foundation

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

greater than **Subject:** Polity · **Tier:** Basic (foundation) · **GS Paper:** GS-II

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE FOUNDATION: RECALL MAP

Core Foundation

Dimension 1

greater than Subject: Polity · Tier: Basic (foundation) · GS
Paper: GS-II

Dimension 2

greater than Grounded in: Laxmikant Ch. 13. □ = from book ·
□□ = inference · □ = current affairs.

Dimension 3

greater than Full depth: advanced/12Federal-System.md.

STATIC THEORY

• greater than **Grounded in:** Laxmikant Ch. 13. □ = from book · □□ = inference · □ = current affairs.

• greater than *Full depth: advanced/12_Federal-System.md.*

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. greater than **Grounded in:** Laxmikant Ch. 13. = from book · □□ = inference · □ = current affairs.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Core Foundation

HIGH

Foundation • Snapshot

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the foundation source layer.

KEY DATA

Item	Fact
□ Word "Federation" in Constitution	Never used — Art 1 says "Union of States"
□ Model borrowed from	Canada (strong centre), NOT USA
□ Formed by	Disintegration ("holding together")
□ Reasons	Large size + socio-cultural diversity
□ 7th Schedule lists	Union (98), State (59), Concurrent (52); residuary → Centre

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Snapshot

HIGH**Foundation · Core idea****GS-II** Indian
Polity**INTRO & ORIGIN**

□ Powers are **divided by the Constitution itself** between Centre & states (federal), but the balance is deliberately **tilted toward the Centre** (unitary bias). Hence India is **federal in form, unitary in spirit** — a "quasi-federal" state.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Powers are **divided by the Constitution itself** between Centre & states (federal), but the balance is deliberately **tilted toward the Centre** (unitary bias). Hence India is **federal in form, unitary in spirit** — a "quasi-federal" state.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Core idea

HIGH**Foundation · 7 Federal features****GS-II** Indian
Polity**INTRO & ORIGIN**

greater than □ **Mnemonic: "Dual Writing Divides Supreme Rigid Independent Bicameral" = Dual polity** ·

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

7 FEDERAL FEATURES: RECALL MAP**7 Federal features**

Dimension 1 greater than □ Mnemonic: "Dual Writing Divides Supreme Rigid Independent Bicameral" = Dual polity ·	Dimension 2 greater than Written Constitution · Division of powers · Supremacy of Constitution · Rigidity ·
Dimension 3 greater than Independent judiciary · Bicameralism.	

STATIC THEORY

- greater than **Written Constitution** · **Division of powers** · **Supremacy of Constitution** · **Rigidity** ·
- greater than **Independent judiciary** · **Bicameralism**.

MEMORY HOOK

greater than **Mnemonic: "Dual Writing Divides Supreme Rigid Independent Bicameral" = Dual polity** ·

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ 7 Federal features

HIGH

Foundation • Unitary features (the 14) — high-yield

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ Strong Centre • destructible states • single Constitution • flexibility • unequal RS seats • emergency provisions • single citizenship • integrated judiciary • All-India Services • integrated audit (CAG) • Parliament over State List (Art 249) • Governor as Centre's agent • integrated ECI • President's veto over state bills.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Strong Centre • destructible states • single Constitution • flexibility • unequal RS seats • emergency provisions • single citizenship • integrated judiciary • All-India Services • integrated audit (CAG) • Parliament over State List (Art 249) • Governor as Centre's agent • integrated ECI • President's veto over state bills.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Unitary features (the 14) — high-yield

HIGH

Foundation • Scholar tags (learn these!)

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

greater than □ Match: Wheare → "quasi-federal" • Morris Jones → "bargaining federalism" •

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

SCHOLAR TAGS (LEARN THESE!): RECALL MAP

Scholar tags (learn these!)

Dimension 1

greater than □ Match: Wheare → "quasi-federal" • Morris Jones → "bargaining federalism" •

Dimension 2

greater than Jennings → "centralising tendency" • Alexandrowicz → "sui generis" •

Dimension 3

greater than Granville Austin → "cooperative federalism" • Paul Appleby → "extremely federal".

STATIC THEORY

- greater than Jennings → "centralising tendency" • Alexandrowicz → "sui generis" •
- greater than Granville Austin → "cooperative federalism" • Paul Appleby → "extremely federal".

MEMORY HOOK

greater than Match: Wheare → "quasi-federal" • Morris Jones → "bargaining federalism" •

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Scholar tags (learn these!)

HIGH

Foundation • Must-Know Facts

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

□ India = "indestructible Union of **destructible states**"; USA = "...of indestructible states".

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MUST-KNOW FACTS: RECALL MAP

Must-Know Facts

Dimension 1

□ India = "indestructible Union of destructible states"; USA = "...of indestructible states".

Dimension 2

□ Residuary powers → Centre (opposite of USA).

Dimension 3

□ S.R. Bommai (1994): federalism is a basic feature; states are not appendages.

Dimension 4

□ Only exception to single Constitution was pre-2019 J&K.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Residuary powers → Centre (opposite of USA).
- □ S.R. Bommai (1994): federalism is a **basic feature**; states are **not appendages**.
- □ Only exception to single Constitution was **pre-2019 J&K**.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. India = "indestructible Union of **destructible states**"; USA = "...of indestructible states".
2. Residuary powers → Centre (opposite of USA).
3. S.R. Bommai (1994): federalism is a **basic feature**; states are **not appendages**.
4. Only exception to single Constitution was **pre-2019 J&K**.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Must-Know Facts

HIGH

Foundation • □ Current link

GS-II Indian
Polity

NEWS TRIGGER

□ □ □ GST coordination, fiscal-devolution demands and bill-assent disputes keep federalism live. For assent, use the controlling **20 Nov 2025 Article 143 opinion**: no rigid judicial timelines/deemed assent, but prolonged unexplained inaction is reviewable. □ □ For all 7 federal + 14 unitary features, scholar quotes & Bommai → advanced/12_Federal-System.md.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of □ Current link.

Foundation learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ [Current link](#)

HIGH

Advanced • Core Foundation

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

greater than **Subject:** Polity · **Tier:** Advanced (exam depth) · **GS Paper:** GS-II

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

CORE FOUNDATION: RECALL MAP

Core Foundation

Dimension 1

greater than Subject: Polity · Tier: Advanced (exam depth) ·
GS Paper: GS-II

Dimension 2

greater than Grounded in: Indian Polity by M. Laxmikant, Ch. 13 / "Federal System" (direct check of the local Sixth Revised Edition PDF).

Dimension 3

greater than ☐ = from source book · ☐☐ = inference · ☐ =
current affairs.

Dimension 4

greater than Companion: basic/Federal-System.md.

STATIC THEORY

• greater than **Grounded in:** Indian Polity by M. Laxmikant, Ch. 13 / "Federal System" (direct check of the local Sixth Revised Edition PDF).

• greater than ☐ = from source book · ☐☐ = inference · ☐ = current affairs.

• greater than *Companion: basic/Federal-System.md.*

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. greater than = from source book · ☐☐ = inference · ☐ = current affairs.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ [Core Foundation](#)

HIGH

Advanced • Federal vs unitary

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

☐ **Unitary** = all powers in the national govt (regions derive authority from it) — Britain, France, Japan, China. **Federal** = powers **divided by the Constitution itself**; both levels operate independently — USA, Switzerland, Australia, Canada, Russia. ☐ "Federation" ← Latin **foedus** = "treaty/agreement". Units called states (US), cantons (Switzerland), provinces (Canada), republics (Russia).

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

FEDERAL VS UNITARY: RECALL MAP

Federal vs unitary

Dimension 1 □ Unitary = all powers in the national govt (regions derive authority from it) — Britain, France, Japan, China. Federal = powers divided by the Consti	Dimension 2 □ Two ways to form a federation: (i) integration — weak states unite into a strong union (USA, oldest federation, 1787, "coming together"); (ii) disintegration — a big unitary state grants autonomy to provinces (Canada 1867, "holding together"). □ India followed the Canadian route (disintegration → strong centre).
Dimension 3 □ India adopted federalism due to (i) large size and (ii) socio-cultural diversity — reconciling national unity with regional autonomy. □ "Federation"	

STATIC THEORY

- **Two ways to form a federation:** (i) **integration** — weak states unite into a strong union (**USA**, oldest federation, 1787, "coming together"); (ii) **disintegration** — a big unitary state grants autonomy to provinces (**Canada** 1867, "holding together"). □ **India followed the Canadian route** (disintegration → strong centre).
- India adopted federalism due to (i) **large size** and (ii) **socio-cultural diversity** — reconciling **national unity with regional autonomy**. □ **"Federation" is NEVER used** in the Constitution — Art 1 says **"Union of States"** (Ambedkar: not an agreement, no right to secede → indestructible). □ Indian model = **Canadian** (strong centre), not American: resemblance in (i) formation by disintegration, (ii) term "Union", (iii) centralising tendency.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

- Unitary** = all powers in the national govt (regions derive authority from it) — Britain, France, Japan, China. **Federal** = powers **divided by the Constitution itself**; both levels operate independently — USA, Switzerland, Australia, Canada, Russia. "Federation" ← Latin **foedus** = "treaty/agreement". Units called states (US), cantons (Switzerland), provinces (Canada), republics (Russia).
- Two ways to form a federation:** (i) **integration** — weak states unite into a strong union (**USA**, oldest federation, 1787, "coming together"); (ii) **disintegration** — a big unitary state grants autonomy to provinces (**Canada** 1867, "holding together"). **India followed the Canadian route** (disintegration → strong centre).
- India adopted federalism due to (i) **large size** and (ii) **socio-cultural diversity** — reconciling **national unity with regional autonomy**. **"Federation" is NEVER used** in the Constitution — Art 1 says **"Union of States"** (Ambedkar: not an agreement, no right to secede → indestructible). Indian model = **Canadian** (strong centre), not American: resemblance in (i) formation by disintegration, (ii) term "Union", (iii) centralising tendency.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Federal vs unitary

HIGH

Advanced · Federal features (7) □

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

#	Feature	Detail
□ 1	Dual polity	Union at centre + states at periphery, each sovereign in its field
□ 2	Written Constitution	Longest in world; defines structure/powers/limits of both levels
□ 3	Division of powers	7th Schedule — Union List (98), State List (59), Concurrent List (52) ; residuary → Centre
□ 4	Supremacy of Constitution	Highest law; laws violating it struck down via judicial review
□ 5	Rigid Constitution	Federal provisions need special majority + ratification by half the states
□ 6	Independent judiciary	SC guards Constitution + settles Centre-state/inter-state disputes
□ 7	Bicameralism	Rajya Sabha (states) + Lok Sabha (people); RS maintains federal equilibrium

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — **ADVANCED / COMPLETE**
→ Federal features (7) □

HIGH

Advanced · Unitary features (14) □□ (very high-yield) ·
Table 1.1

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

#	Feature	Key point
□ 1	Strong Centre	Union List longer + more important subjects; Centre overrides Concurrent; residuary to Centre (in US → states)
□ 2	States not indestructible	Parliament can alter area/boundary/name by simple majority → "indestructible Union of destructible states"
□ 3	Single Constitution	States can't frame own constitution (exception: pre-2019 J&K;)
□ 4	Flexibility	Bulk amendable unilaterally by Parliament; only Centre can initiate amendment (US → states can too)
□ 5	No equal state representation	Rajya Sabha seats by population (1 to 31) ; US Senate = 2 per state
□ 6	Emergency provisions	National/state/financial — converts federal → unitary without amendment
□ 7	Single citizenship	Like Canada; no separate state citizenship
□ 8	Integrated judiciary	SC → HCs, one system enforcing both Central & state laws (US = double courts)

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — **ADVANCED / COMPLETE**
→ Unitary features (14) □□ (very high-yield)

HIGH

Advanced · Unitary features (14) □□ (very high-yield) ·
Table 1.2

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

#	Feature	Key point
□ 9	All-India Services	IAS/IPS/IFS common to Centre & states, controlled by Centre — "violate federalism"
□ 10	Integrated audit	CAG audits states too; appointed/removed by President without consulting states
□ 11	Parliament's authority over State List	Art 249 — RS resolution lets Parliament legislate on State List in national interest (no emergency needed)
□ 12	Appointment of Governor	Appointed by President, holds office at his pleasure, acts as Centre's agent (US → elected)
□ 13	Integrated election machinery	ECI runs Central & state elections; states have no say
□ 14	Veto over state bills	Governor reserves bills for President, who has absolute veto (not suspensive)

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

Federal System — **ADVANCED / COMPLETE**
→ Unitary features (14) □□ (very high-yield)

HIGH

Advanced · Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Structured comparison from the advanced source layer.

KEY DATA

Scholar	Characterisation
□ K.C. Wheare	"Quasi-federal" — "unitary state with subsidiary federal features"
□ K. Santhanam	Unitary bias from (i) Centre's financial dominance, (ii) erstwhile Planning Commission
□ Paul Appleby	"Extremely federal"
□ Morris Jones	"Bargaining federalism"
□ Ivor Jennings	"Federation with a strong centralising tendency"
□ Alexandrowicz	"Sui generis" (unique)
□ Granville Austin	"Cooperative federalism" — "a new kind of federation for India's needs"

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite)

HIGH

Advanced · Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite)

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite).

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

□ **Ambedkar**: Constitution is federal (dual polity; both derive authority from the Constitution) but "can be **both unitary and federal** according to the requirements of time and circumstances." □ **S.R. Bommai v. UoI (1994)**: Constitution is **federal** and federalism is a **basic feature**; states are **not mere appendages** — "within the sphere allotted to them, the states are supreme." □ Indian federalism = compromise between (i) normal division of powers (state autonomy) & (ii) national integrity + strong Union in exceptional circumstances.

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Critical evaluation — scholar tags □□ (PYQ favourite)

HIGH

Advanced · UPSC Traps

GS-II Indian Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of UPSC Traps.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The word "Federation" appears in the Constitution

CORRECT: **never**; Art 1 uses "**Union of States**".

WRONG: India follows the American federal model

CORRECT: **Canadian** model (strong centre, disintegration, "Union").

WRONG: Residuary powers rest with states

CORRECT: with the **Centre** (opposite of US).

WRONG: Wheare called India "federal"

CORRECT: "**quasi-federal**".

WRONG: Cooperative federalism was coined by Ambedkar

CORRECT: by **Granville Austin**.

WRONG: Rajya Sabha gives equal seats to states

CORRECT: by **population (1–31)**; only the US Senate is equal.

WRONG: Bommai diluted federalism

CORRECT: it **affirmed** federalism as a **basic feature**.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ UPSC Traps

HIGH**Advanced • CA hooks**GS-II Indian
Polity**NEWS TRIGGER**

□ □ □ Live federal frictions: GST coordination, **Governor's delay in assenting to bills** (read with the 20 Nov 2025 Article 143 opinion), **NEET/education (Concurrent List)**, river-water disputes (Cauvery), and **fiscal-devolution** demands from southern states — all illustrate "bargaining"/ "cooperative" federalism in action.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of □ CA hooks.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ □ CA hooks

HIGH

Advanced • Mains angles

GS-II Indian
Polity

INTRO & ORIGIN

Exam-ready treatment of Mains angles.

Advanced learning layer: concepts → constitutional detail → UPSC application.

MAINS ANGLE

"Indian federalism is a case sui generis." Discuss with recent Centre-state frictions. Cooperative vs competitive vs coercive federalism — which best describes India today? Do the 14 unitary features make India a "unitary state with federal features"? Evaluate post-Bommai.

STUDY LINK

Federal System — ADVANCED / COMPLETE
→ Mains angles

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI